

- 1 In the first paragraph, how does the author illustrate his description of Nero as ‘vain’? [1]

From the Passage	Paraphrased / Inferred
“Brutal, neglectful and vain, Nero currently enjoys a reputation as one of the worst of the Roman emperors” (lines 1 to 2) “Nero’s park... featured both open spaces for relaxation (as well as numerous statues of himself.)” (lines 9 to 10)	A: The author points out the fact that Nero had erected numerous statues of himself in his park to show that Nero was ‘vain’. <i>(Student must find the right example to illustrate ‘vanity’)</i>

- 2 What is the author implying by using the word ‘currently’ to describe Nero’s reputation (line 1)? [1]

From the Passage	Paraphrased / Inferred
“Brutal, neglectful and vain, Nero currently enjoys a reputation as one of the worst of the Roman emperors” (lines 1 to 2)	The writer is implying that Nero’s reputation may change over time [B], but it is at this point in time [A] a poor reputation. [1] <i>(Student must bring out the idea of ‘currently’. This should not be merely a paraphrasing exercise where [A] ‘currently’ is replaced with a synonym. [B] The context that the reputation “might have changed” or “might not have always been the same” should be captured as well.)</i>

- 3 What is the author implying by using the word ‘cocooned’ to describe the solo jogger? [1]

From the Passage	Paraphrased
...from the solo jogger cocooned by his earphones from social contact... [lines 17-18]	He is implying that the solo jogger is wrapped up in his own world ([A] physically and [B] socially)/ cut off from the world around him. [1] <i>Note: Do not accept answers that only suggest physical isolation (eg. isolated/ physically alone). Context of ‘cut off from the world around him’ is necessary.</i>

- 4 What is the author hinting at by his use of the words ‘momentarily at least’ (line 21)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Passage	Paraphrased
“..whilst children revel in the opportunity to run and play in the open air, away – momentarily at least – from less vigorous counter counter-attractions at home..”	A (momentarily): Writer is hinting that this respite that children have in open spaces is temporary/short-lived/fleeting, B (at least): but it is still better than nothing. [Student MUST note the 2 separate ideas in the phrase for a 2m question] <i>[2 or 0.]</i>

- 5 When the author writes that activities in parks are ‘impromptu, purposeless, and ungainful’ (line 32), what is he implying in each case about the values of the world outside the park? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [3]

From the Passage	Paraphrased / Inferred / Flipped
The activities in the parks are...	The world outside the park is characterized by...
impromptu	A: planning, preparation [1] <i>haste/unhurried and other speed-related words [0]</i>
purposeless	B: target -setting, meeting objectives [1]
ungainful	C: quest for/attaining tangible benefits [1] <i>meaningful, fruitfulness, profitability [0]</i>

- 6 Explain what is ironic about parks and green spaces being ‘sanctuaries of calm’ in paragraph 3. [2]

From the Passage	Inferred
In these sanctuaries of calm we can do nothing at all... (line 31)	A1 (Expectation): While it is expected that “sanctuaries” are far away from the world/boisterous crowds, B1 (Reality): ...in reality, the parks and green spaces that have been characterised as such are still within the city and swamped with all manner of activities. OR A2 (Expectation): Places of refuge are expected to be private/ quiet/ cut-off, B2 (Reality): ...but in reality, parks and green spaces are public, highly accessible and possibly a hive of activity [2 or 0.]

- 7 What is the author’s purpose in describing the process whereby trees cool and filter the air as being ‘like perspiration from our skin’ and ‘like lungs’ (lines 41-42)? [2]

From the Passage	
...partly by providing shade, but mostly through water evaporation from leaves, like perspiration from our skin... (lines 41-42) ..trees and plants are link lungs, filtering the air and water of pollutants...(lines 42-43)	A: The author creates an analogy. Trees are like human beings work similarly in some aspects/mechanisms – breathing and cooling through perspiration. [1] <i>If student mentions ‘analogy’ without explanation [0]</i> B: He also suggests that trees contribute significantly/are vital/crucial to our well-being. [1] <i>He wants to highlight significance of trees [0]</i>

- 8 In what ways does the entrance policy of High Line (lines 52-53) differ from the general principles of access to parks described in paragraph two? Use your own words as far as possible. [2]

From the Passage	Paraphrased / Inferred
Today, the many pedestrians drawn to the High Line seem undeterred by the restrictions on its use: no joggers, skateboarders, or cyclists; no music, alcohol or pets. (line 51-55) <u>Context:</u> Today's city parks and public spaces are valuable and cherished because they offer something for everyone: they are instruments of social cohesion. There is room for a myriad of activities: sporting, from the solo jogger cocooned by his earphones from social contact, to gregarious footballers; artistic, from people writing, reading or painting in some secluded sport to participating in open-air exhibitions and concerts...like the television and the internet. (lines 15-22)	A: High Line's policy gives importance to quiet enjoyment/peaceful pleasures/calm appreciation/admiration of the environment/experience of serenity/tranquillity [1] B: hence it outlaws/prohibits/bans/forbids any activity with the potential to disturb/disrupt that while other parks do not. [1] <i>(Note: Students must capture the difference in policy as well as the principles behind it to warrant the full 2m)</i>

- 9 Explain how the author justifies his use of the word 'illusory' to describe visits to zoos and botanical gardens (lines 68-70). **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Passage	Paraphrased
...it is a stage-managed wildness we may never actually visit for real...(line 69)	A: The author suggests that zoos and botanical gardens are artificially managed/artificially engineered/shaped and controlled by man
...easily available for an afternoon's perusal. (line 69-70)	B1: The author also claims that these facilities are accessible/do not require great effort to reach/convenient B2: and that they offer short term/brief entertainment/satisfaction/immersion <i>Answer must contain both B1 and B2 to be awarded the full mark.</i>

	(Note: Student should note that the use of the semi-colon in line 68 suggests that the idea of 'illusory' is developed and explained in the subsequent lines)
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- 10 Suggest one reason for the author ending the passage with the Latin phrase *rus in urbe* (line 79) [1]

From the Passage	Inferred
...to encourage what the Romans called <i>rus in urbe</i>: the country in the city. (lines 78-79)	A: The use of the Latin phrase neatly concludes the passage which began with the Roman story of Nero. OR B: To remind us that the practice of building the civic parks began with a Roman emperor / had its roots in the Roman empire <i>It is for emphasis or effect</i> [0]

- 11 Using material from paragraphs 2-4 only (lines 12-45), summarise what the author has to say about the benefits that parks and green spaces have for individuals and cities. Write your summary in **no more than 120 words**, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible. [8]**

Parks and green spaces are of benefit because...

#	From the Passage	Paraphrase	Key Idea
1	Crowded and squalid cities have needed green areas for the populace to enjoy	Reprieve(pleasurable green spaces for people) from overpopulated cities	Enjoyment
2	Offer something for everyone: they are instruments of social cohesion	Bring people together	Unity
3	Sporting, from the solo jogger	Is a venue for the individual	Individual activities
4	Gregarious footballers	And group activities	Group activities
5	Sporting , from the solo jogger cocooned... artistic , from people writing, reading or painting in some secluded spot to participating in open-air exhibitions and concerts	Take part in activities ranging from sports to aesthetics	Sports to aesthetics
6	Romantically inclined , parks are natural locations for assignations	Parks are used for a romantic rendezvous	Venue for romantic rendezvous
7	Children revel in the opportunity to run and play in the open air ... away from less vigorous counter-actions at home...	Place to relax/children engage in wholesome activities away from undesirable distractions at home.	(Children) given a much-deserved opportunity to relax with nature
8	More psychological reasons... improve our well-being... (parks do not) endanger impatience, a focus on the instant, the latest, the superficial (line 23-25) Soothing to the stressed soul (line 35)	Better our psychological health by (slowing down and focusing on the authentic) Helps the mind to relax	Psychological well-being improved

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Suggested Answer Scheme

9	Our green spaces give us a sense of not being in a city at all...but of having stepped aside, temporarily at least, from noise and pressure into an environment where we can pause, reflect and recharge. Soothing to the stressed soul	Divert our attention away from urban life /Getaway from the hustle and bustle as well as stress in the city	Divert our focus from the hustle and bustle and stress in the city/ stress-buster
10	Parks are pleasing unaltered (line 30)	Parks seem to be reassuringly constant in a world of continual change	Constant /unchanging
11	Sanctuaries of calm we can do nothing at all, guiltlessly (line 31)	Peaceful/Serene place where we do not feel guilty not doing anything	Peaceful place where not doing anything is fine
12	Pursue activities that are impromptu, purposeless and ungainful (line 32)	Able to do things spontaneously and uninhibited by pragmatic concerns	Do spontaneous activities for their own enjoyment and not for any other practical purpose.
13	Vital counterbalance to the perceived debilitating impact cities have on the environment (line 38)	Bulwark of biodiversity	Protects biodiversity
15	Cities heat.. vegetation cools.. shade (line 40)	Reduce heat	Reduces heat
16	Lungs filtering the air and water of pollutants (line 42)	Detoxify the atmosphere/Sieves out pollutants	Detoxify the environment
17	Increase the capture of rainwater, improve drainage (line 43)	Enhance the water system	Enhance the water system
18	Reduce noise pollution by dense screening...(line 44)	Lower excessive noise	Lower excessive noise
19	Provide habitats for a diversity of species of wildlife. (line 45)	Allow for fauna to flourish	Fauna to flourish

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SAMPLE:

Parks and green spaces are of benefit because they offer a reprieve from overpopulated cities and unite communities. These venues allow individuals and groups to engage in activities which are athletic or aesthetic. Couples use it for romantic rendezvous while children get the opportunity to play in the open. Parks are a place to relax, divert our attention from the stresses of urbanisation and better our psychological health by not focusing on depthless matters. Parks are reassuringly constant in a world of continual change. It is a peaceful place which allows us to idle without reproach or be spontaneous and uninhibited by pragmatic concerns. Parks act as a bulwark of biodiversity, reducing heat, detoxifying the atmosphere, improving the drainage system, lowering excessive noise and allowing for fauna to flourish. (121 words)

Mark Allocation:

Number of points	Marks Allocated
14 or more	8
12-13	7
10-11	6
8-9	5
6-7	4
4-5	3
2-3	2
1	1

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- 12 In this article, Brendan Thomas makes a number of observations about how valuable parks and green spaces are to cities and their inhabitants. How applicable do you find his observations to yourself and your own society?

Observations from the article	Evaluation	Applicability to Singapore
Paragraph 2 Green parks are “instruments of social cohesion” (line 16)	Parks generally do not charge an admission fee – allowing people both rich and poor to enter and make use of the facilities. A diverse range of activities are found in such areas (cycling, kite-flying, jogging, strolling, offering something to do for everyone.	Public, open green space such as parks or the Marina Barrage is well-received, but Gardens by the Bay charge a hefty admission price and seems to be profit-driven and operates like a tourist attraction. This prevents the average Singaporean from making use of these facilities, and it might remain as something which is only enjoyed by the rich, limiting the potential of the Garden being an “instrument of social cohesion”. Observations were made in the newspapers that parks in the HDB estates seem to be where migrant workers congregate because they are free-of-charge and these workers with low income usually do not have access to technological gadgets (computers, televisions, etc) which the more affluent Singaporeans have access to for entertainment and relaxation. Again, this suggests that parks are not necessarily ideal spaces for building social bonds
Paragraph 3 Green spaces offer us respite from urban life.	Singaporeans live hectic and fast-paced lifestyles, and white-collared workers also lead rather sedentary lifestyles spending a lot of time sitting in front of a computer at the office desk. Singaporeans are often far-removed from nature, being overly reliant on artificial air-conditioned environments. Parks and green spaces provide Singaporeans with the much needed escape (albeit temporarily) from our unhealthy lifestyles. Given the climate and humidity of Singapore, Singaporeans might not necessarily find these parks attractive. Air-conditioned malls and other indoor entertainment venues might be more appealing to Singaporeans, where plenty of indoor activities (eating, shopping, bowling, singing karaoke, movies, going for a spa treatment) entertain and occupy Singaporeans during their free time.	Community parks are scattered around the island, often in residential neighbourhoods. Park connectors (especially in the East, e.g. Siglap, Tampines and Pasir Ris park connectors) are used for cyclists and pedestrians to move from one park to another seamlessly. These green areas are accessible and within easy reach from the heartlanders – providing the much needed break from the urban sprawl. On the other hand, it must be remembered that most of these green spaces found in Singapore are ultimately artificial and landscaped. Truly natural green space, like those in Pulau Ubin, Bukit Timah Nature Reserve or Chek Jawa remain few in number. This is not surprising given that much of the land is used for development and economic activities and land scarcity remains a problem in Singapore.
Paragraph 5 Ecological and economic benefits go hand in hand	The cynical Singaporean might argue that profit-making remains an important factor in how we make use of green space in Singapore.	Night Safari and Singapore Zoological Gardens are one of the most expensive zoos in the world, and seemed to be designed as a tourist attraction rather than something for residents to enjoy. The shops and restaurants found in such areas are relatively up-market and costly.

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Suggested Answer Scheme

		The newest Gardens by the Bay also seem to be designed in the same vein. Although the decision to set aside green space in the Central Business District can be seen as an indication of the commitment towards a “Garden City” by the government,
Paragraph 6 Smaller and more local scale – community gardens, gardens in courtyards and roofs	Given Singapore’s limited land, roof gardens and similar forms of delocalised green space seem to be the most common way to make use of green space. Green roofs have been found to reduce the ambient temperature of the building by as much as 4 degrees Celsius – potentially saving the amount of money spent on electricity which might be needed to cool the building.	Community gardening remains a popular activity, especially amongst the elderly Singaporeans. They tend to small plots of land within their neighbourhood estate, and many of them are immensely proud of the plants which they have cultivated.
Paragraph 7 Green spaces elicit protective attitudes from city-dwellers because there is a remnant of the countryside dweller in all of us – a memory where contact with nature was seen as vital. The experience of wildness is illusory: it is a stage-managed wildness we may never actually visit for real, easily available for an afternoon’s perusal.	Brendan Thomas provides an overly romanticised view of green spaces here. Few Singaporeans would have this kind of protective mindset – in fact, the untamed nature is seen as something dirty, dangerous and uncomfortable. Children are often discouraged from playing in the parks, and have minimum contact with plants or animals as such conditions are seen as unsanitary. While Singaporeans may appreciate green space as an occasional respite from the concrete jungle, the pragmatic nature of Singaporeans ultimately takes over and green space is unlikely to be prioritized over potentially more profitable and lucrative use of land space.	The green spaces in Singapore are indeed managed and regulated – the Flower Domes in the Gardens by the Bay are micro-managed ecosystems which replicate conditions not found in Singapore in order to plant a wide variety of attractive ferns and flowers. The Botanical Gardens and Zoological Gardens are also artificially recreated habitats. However, this is an inevitability of living in land-scarce Singapore, and is a reasonable compromise as it would not be feasible to leave huge tracts of untamed wilderness in Singapore just to provide a getaway from urban living.

Note:

Some ideas are raised or hinted at repeatedly throughout the passage (e.g. the contrived nature of green spaces found in cities) therefore it can be difficult to categorise ideas raised by the writer strictly by paragraphs.